

Is a Finance Degree Worth It in the AI Era?

The already-in-it guide — the full scores by track, the six factors behind them, and what to do from where you already are.

8.0

AI EXPOSURE · ENTRY ANALYST / RESEARCH
where 10 is most at risk

For anyone already in it — in the degree, or job-hunting.



Before you read this

The choice is already made — you're in a finance degree or training, or out of one and into the job hunt. So this guide skips the "should you study finance" question and goes straight to the one that's actually live: given where you already are, what do you do about it?

It's written to you directly — whether you are the one in it, or a parent reading on their behalf. Where it says "you," a parent can simply read "them"; the moves are the same either way.

What this is. A facts document, not a pep talk. It sets out what's known about where finance sits in an AI economy, where the evidence is contested, and where we might be wrong — and then what to actually do from here.

The good news, up front. Already in it is not too late — not close. Finance isn't one destination, it's a wide spread of them, from 4.6 to 8.0, and almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Where you land inside that range is decided mostly by moves still in front of you — chiefly, whether you steer toward the tiers where someone is answerable to a client rather than the spreadsheet rung everyone starts in. The second half of this guide is those moves.

And one thing specific to finance. The timing matters more here than in any other guide: investment banking summer analyst applications open up to eighteen months in advance, which means the decision is effectively made in the first year of university rather than the third. If you're early in the degree and banking is of any interest, that clock is the first thing to check. And be careful with the sources — finance is unusually well covered by recruiting firms with a commercial interest in optimism. We've leaned on Bureau of Labor Statistics data where possible and flagged where we're relying on industry commentary instead.

The short answer

Finance protects the relationship and judgment tiers — advising people, managing risk, owning decisions. It offers much less to the spreadsheet tier, which is both the most automatable work we score in this family and the traditional way in.

Wealth and financial advisory scores 4.6 out of 10. An entry-level analyst role scores 8.0.

Finance protects the person in the room with the client, and offers very little to the person preparing the materials for that room.

Which one you become is decided mostly from here.

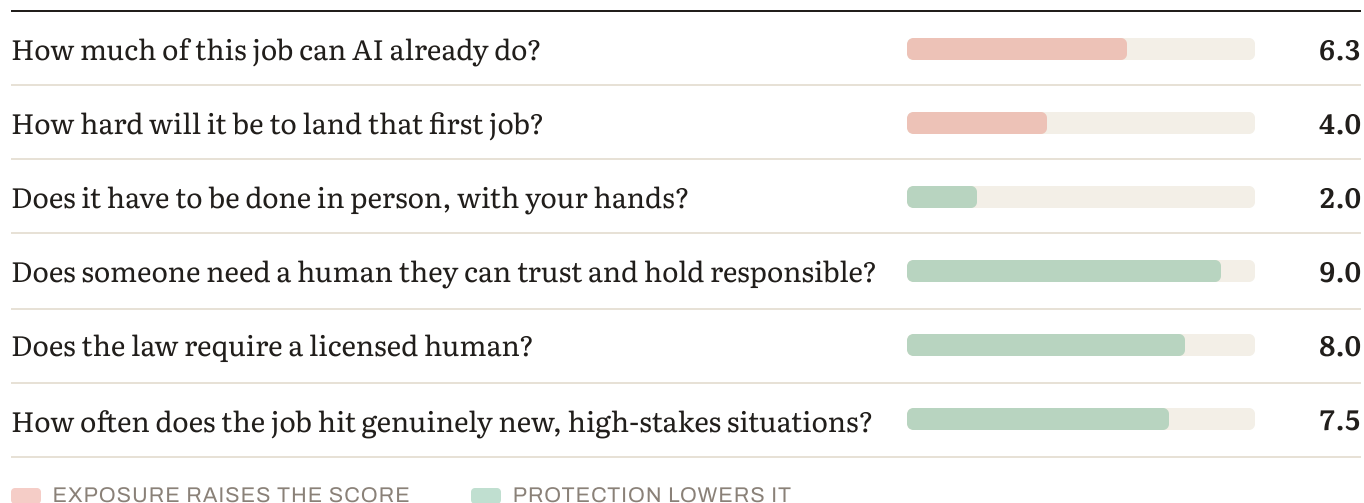
The scores

TRACK	2023	2025	FALL 2026	3-YR MOVEMENT	BAND
Wealth / financial advisory	3.9	4.2	4.6	+0.7	Low-Moderate
Risk & compliance	4.5	4.8	5.3	+0.8	Moderate
Investment banking (senior)	4.9	5.3	5.7	+0.8	Moderate
Corporate finance / FP&A	6.0	6.4	6.8	+0.8	Moderate-High
Entry analyst / research	6.4	7.3	8.0	+1.6	High

Scores run 1–10, where 10 is most at risk. For context: the median profession in this edition sits around 5.5, CPA advisory scores 5.2, a business analyst 7.6, and entry-level software development 8.1.

Read the table this way: the spread is 3.4 points — one of the widest we measure — and it falls almost exactly along the line of who is personally answerable to a client. Your job, from here, is to move toward the accountable end of the table — not to hope the table moves.

Why finance scores the way it does — the six factors



Here's how an entry-level analyst answers them — the exposed end, and where most graduates start. Knowing *why* the entry role scores 8.0 while advisory holds at 4.6 is what tells you which way to move.

HOW MUCH OF THIS JOB CAN AI ALREADY DO? (35% OF THE SCORE)

Nearly all of it, and this is the cleanest example in the index of a role built entirely from automatable tasks.

Financial modeling and scenario building. Company and sector research. Earnings analysis and comparables. Pitch book and deck production. Data assembly and cleaning. First-draft memos and commentary.

That list is a substantially complete description of a first-year analyst's job. Not adjacent to it — it is it.

What resists: sitting across from someone making the biggest financial decision of their life, judgment on risks that don't match historical patterns, being called when markets fall, and regulatory accountability for advice given. Those are the things to be moving toward.

HOW HARD WILL IT BE TO LAND THAT FIRST JOB? (15%)

Severe, and compounded by something our framework doesn't measure.

Industry commentary consistently reports hiring as **strongest at associate and vice-president level rather than analyst level** — firms buying experience rather than building it, the same pattern documented in law and consulting.

And there's a supply problem alongside it. Finance attracts enormous application volumes at the glamorous end while risk, compliance and operations roles struggle to fill. Two entirely

different labor markets sharing a degree.

The way through isn't to wait for the analyst rung to widen — the content of it has changed even where the seats remain. It's to enter *beside* it: through the internship that is now the filter rather than one input among several, and through the under-applied lanes — wealth advisory (4.6), risk and compliance (5.3) — that score better and hire more readily than the oversubscribed banking rung everyone aims at. A seat being on offer at the exposed end is not the same as a future there. That's a set of concrete moves, and the career-hunting checklist later in this guide lays them out.

DOES IT HAVE TO BE DONE IN PERSON, WITH YOUR HANDS? (15%)

None of it. Finance is text and numbers in, judgments out. No physical protection at all.

DOES SOMEONE NEED A HUMAN THEY CAN TRUST AND HOLD RESPONSIBLE? (15%)

At the advisory tier absolutely; at the analyst tier barely at all. The section on the person in the room versus the person preparing for it covers this properly, because it does most of the work in this guide.

DOES THE LAW REQUIRE A LICENSED HUMAN? (10%)

For regulated advice, meaningfully.

Licensing, registration and fiduciary or suitability obligations attach to a named human advisor. Regulatory accountability cannot be delegated to a system, and it moves at the speed of legislation rather than technology.

For an unregulated analyst producing internal materials, none of this applies.

HOW OFTEN DOES THE JOB HIT GENUINELY NEW, HIGH-STAKES SITUATIONS? (10%)

At the advisory and risk tiers frequently. A client's circumstances are individual, and risk judgments on non-pattern events are exactly where models are weakest. Building a comparables table is the opposite. The distance between those two is the distance you're trying to close.

The person in the room versus the person preparing for it

Finance is almost entirely screen-based. Nobody in it is protected by physical presence. So one factor does most of the work separating a 4.6 from an 8.0, and it's worth understanding

precisely.

Two things sit inside our trust factor. *Trust*: does someone need a specific human they can rely on? *Accountability*: must a human carry responsibility when it goes wrong?

A financial advisor rates 9.0 on both. Clients hand over decisions about retirement, a house, a child's education, an inheritance. When markets fall they want to speak to a person who knows their situation and can be held to the advice they gave. Fiduciary and suitability obligations attach to a licensed human.

An entry-level analyst rates 4.0. They produce work someone else signs off. No client knows their name. Nobody relies on them personally, and no regulatory obligation attaches to them individually. The work is real and the accountability sits above them.

The pattern generalises across this whole index: exposure falls as personal accountability rises. The further a role sits from someone answering for the outcome, the more exposed it is — which is why the model consistently finds senior work safer than junior work in every profession lacking a physical or licensing moat.

The uncomfortable implication for a finance graduate is that the protection cannot be acquired at the start. It has to be earned, and the roles where you traditionally earned it are the ones being compressed. Which is exactly why the direction you steer now matters more than the seat you happen to start in.

One honest caveat about the trend

Finance is the most cyclical profession we score, and that makes its three-year movement harder to read than any other.

Deal activity slumped sharply in 2023–24 and recovered as rates stabilized. Hiring moved with it. So some portion of the +1.6 on the analyst track is almost certainly the deal cycle rather than automation, and we cannot cleanly separate the two.

What persuades us to hold a high score is the content of the surviving roles rather than their count. Major firms have begun testing whether candidates can direct AI through modeling and research rather than perform it, including in final-round interviews. When a profession redesigns what a first-year is for, the apprenticeship has changed even if headcount recovers.

A graduate can get the analyst seat and still not get the training the seat used to provide.

What we're watching: analyst class sizes through a full deal cycle. If they return to pre-2023 levels and the work returns with them, our score is too high and we'll lower it.

How durable is the protection?

PROTECTION	STRENGTH TODAY	DURABILITY	WHERE THE PRESSURE IS COMING FROM
Human trust / accountability	Strong at advisory tier	Most durable	Clients want a person answerable for their money. Socially and legally rooted.
Regulatory / licensing	Real for regulated advice	Durable	Fiduciary and suitability obligations attach to a named human.
Judgment under novelty	Real at risk and advisory tiers	Eroding slowly	Non-pattern risk judgment resists; standard analysis does not.
Physical / embodied	None	n/a	Finance has never had this.

The honest read. Finance's protections are genuine and both are seniority-dependent. A graduate has neither on day one, and the traditional route to acquiring them is the part under pressure. That's the central fact this guide turns on: the protection is real, but it's earned, and the whole game is getting to it faster than the automation reaches you.

How the role will actually change

WAS THE JOB	IS BECOMING THE JOB
Building the model	Directing the model build, then interrogating it
Researching the company	Verifying research that arrived pre-assembled
Producing the deck	Deciding what the deck should argue
Learning the sector by covering it exhaustively	Learning it... some other way
Advising a client	Unchanged

The fourth row is the real problem. Analysts learned a sector by building every model in it and being corrected. That was brutal and it was the education. Nobody has replaced it, and the profession is running the experiment on a cohort without a control group. Which means the people who go out of their way to understand the sector — not just produce its models — have an edge that's about to get scarcer.

Human strengths that will matter most

1. **Client trust in a crisis** — being the person someone calls when markets fall or their circumstances change. The most durable thing in this guide. 2. **Accountability for advice** — carrying fiduciary responsibility. 3. **Judgment on non-pattern risk** — the event with no historical analog, which is by definition what models miss. 4. **Deciding what question to ask** — the judgment upstream of any analysis. 5. **Verification** — knowing when a generated model or a research summary is confidently wrong.

Notably absent: modeling speed, Excel fluency and volume of research produced. These were the traditional markers of a strong analyst and are the fastest-depreciating. If your current value is mostly on that second list, the work is to shift it onto the first.

And underneath all five, two traits the score can't grade: **curiosity and adaptability**. The specific tools — the modeling suite, the research platform, the risk engine — will turn over many times across a career. The finance professionals who compound are the ones who stay genuinely commercially curious and re-tool fastest, rather than defending the one way of working they trained on. In a field where the entry-level tasks are automating fastest, that flexibility is itself a form of protection — and increasingly it's what firms are hiring for: the trajectory toward the advisory relationship and the accountable seat, not the current modeling speed.

Other things to consider about this job

What's genuinely good about it

The destinations are excellent and the pay is real. Investment banking analyst roles start around **\$85,000–\$100,000**, among the highest graduate starting salaries in any field, and progression is fast for those who stay.

BLS projects **9% growth for financial analysts** — solid, and above the average across all occupations.

What people in finance report as rewarding:

- **Consequence** — the decisions involve real money and real outcomes
- **Pace of learning**, especially in the first few years, which is genuinely steep
- **Intellectual variety** across sectors, companies and situations
- **Optionality** — finance exits into private equity, corporate strategy, industry leadership and entrepreneurship more readily than most careers
- **The advisory relationship**, which people at that end describe in terms much closer to vocation than transaction

And one structural advantage worth naming: the advisory tier is genuinely under-supplied while the glamorous tier is over-subscribed. Everyone applies to investment banking; far fewer apply to wealth management, risk and compliance — which score better and hire more readily.

What's genuinely hard about it

The hours at the banking end are as bad as their reputation, and they are worst during exactly the years many people are forming other parts of their lives.

Geographic concentration is real. Hiring concentrates heavily in a small number of financial centers. That is a life decision as much as a career one.

Competition at entry is extreme, with record application volumes against selective hiring.

And the recruiting timeline is genuinely punishing. Summer analyst applications open up to eighteen months in advance, and full-time offers go primarily to candidates who did the internship. A student who starts thinking about this in year three has, in practical terms, already missed it.

Who this work suits — and who it doesn't

Finance tends to suit people who:

- **Are comfortable with consequence** — being wrong costs money that belongs to someone else
- **Can hold detail and narrative simultaneously** — the numbers and what they mean
- **Are genuinely commercially curious**, not just good at maths
- **Handle pressure without deteriorating**, sustained rather than occasional
- **Can build trust with people older and wealthier than them**, which is the advisory core

It's harder for people who:

- Want **predictable hours** in the first decade
- Need **geographic flexibility**
- Are drawn primarily by **prestige or salary**, who are heavily over-represented among those who leave in years two and three
- Find **sustained high-stakes pressure** corrosive rather than energizing

If some of that second list sounds like you, it isn't a reason to abandon the path — it's a reason to steer toward the parts of finance that fit, chiefly the advisory and risk tiers, which is what the rest of this does.

What else is moving this market

The cycle dominates the short-term picture, which is why the honest caveat about the trend, above, exists.

Where demand is actually growing is not where students are looking. Industry commentary points consistently to restructuring and debt advisory, private capital and secondaries, and risk and compliance driven by regulatory expansion. Meanwhile applications concentrate on the roles that are hardest to get and most exposed at entry.

And an unusual tailwind worth knowing: technology, data-center and digital-infrastructure financing is one of the fastest-growing coverage areas — the AI buildout creating finance work in the same way it created electrical work.

The AI-native advantage — what it actually looks like

The situation: finance was among the earliest adopters, and major firms now explicitly test whether candidates can direct these tools rather than merely use them. Being already in it, close to the work, is a real advantage here — you can build this fluency inside a live internship or first job, which is exactly where it counts.

WHAT AN AI-NATIVE FINANCE PROFESSIONAL LOOKS LIKE

1. Verify. Knowing when a generated model or research summary is confidently wrong. This requires understanding the business well enough to smell an implausible number, which is exactly what the old modeling years used to build.

2. Direct. Framing an analysis precisely enough to get usable output. Firms are testing this explicitly, which tells you how much they value it.

3. Judge what matters. Deciding which question is worth answering — the layer above the analysis, and the one that doesn't automate.

4. Build trust early. Everything in this guide points at the advisory relationship. Anything that puts a graduate in front of clients sooner moves them up the scale.

5. Understand where models fail. Risk work specifically rewards knowing why a model is wrong about a non-pattern event — which is the entire job in a crisis.

All five are available to you now — not after some future qualification. Turning them into concrete moves is the rest of this guide.

Where a finance degree can take you later

Genuinely broad: investment banking and capital markets, private equity and asset management, wealth and financial advisory, risk and compliance, corporate finance and treasury, fintech, and industry leadership including CFO tracks.

The pattern in this index holds exactly. Roles where a named human is answerable to a client or a regulator score better. Roles that produce analysis for someone else to act on score worse. That is the whole map, and it applies at every level of seniority. That map is the compass for every choice below.

Repositioning from here

The program-selection stage is behind you. The useful questions now are different — and the good news bears repeating: almost none of your exposure is fixed yet. Finance is a 3.4-point spread from 4.6 to 8.0, and where you land inside it is decided mostly by things still in front of you. Nearly all of them point the same way: toward the seat where someone is answerable to a client or a regulator.

If you're still in the degree

Three levers, in order of leverage.

1. The destination is the whole game. The entry-analyst and research rung is the exposed one — it's the row that scores worst in this entire guide, at 8.0, and its job description reads like a list of automated tasks. The protected destinations — wealth advisory (4.6), risk and compliance (5.3), senior investment banking (5.7) — are reached by aiming at the room where someone answers for the outcome, not the spreadsheet that feeds it. If you haven't committed to a destination, this is the single highest-leverage decision left. And the under-applied lanes — advisory, risk, compliance — score better *and* hire more readily, because almost nobody your age is applying to them.

2. The recruiting timeline and the internship, while they're still open. If banking is of any interest, the summer analyst clock started in first year — check where you are against it, because missing it is missing it. And whatever the destination, the internship is now the primary filter for full-time offers, not one input among several. Alongside it, take the quantitative modules seriously: statistics, econometrics and modeling as reasoning are the judgment layer verification depends on, and far cheaper to acquire now than to bolt on later.

3. Being answerable to someone, earlier than feels comfortable. The through-line of this whole index is that roles where a named human answers for the outcome score better than roles that feed one — and that doesn't have to wait for seniority. Anything that puts you nearer a client or a regulator, or into risk judgment on non-pattern events, moves you up the scale. That proximity to accountability is the experience that separates the protected end from the exposed floor, and it's the one thing the analyst rung, for all its prestige, doesn't hand you.

If you've graduated and you're job-hunting

Here the title on the offer matters more than it looks, because the most common early-career finance title is also the most exposed.

- **"Entry analyst" and "research" roles are the 8.0.** They're the default graduate destinations and the automating layer at once. Taking one isn't fatal — but take it as a deliberate stepping-stone toward a client-facing or accountable seat, not as the plan. Corporate finance / FP&A (6.8) sits close behind them.
- **Aim at wealth advisory (4.6) and risk and compliance (5.3).** More protected, closer to a client or a regulator, and chronically under-applied-to — which means less competition, not more.
- **Chase the seat closest to accountability.** A role where someone is answerable — to a client, to a regulator — beats one that produces materials for someone else to sign, even at a smaller firm and even for less money.
- **Weigh the accounting comparison honestly.** Licensed CPA advisory scores 5.2 against entry finance at 8.0 — worse pay, better protection, and a license. If protection matters more to you than the banking salary, it's a live option even now.

The AI-native move, from where you stand

You can't undo the last two years, but you can be the graduate who directs these tools rather than competes with them. The five capabilities above — verify, direct, judge what matters, build trust early, understand where models fail — are all available right now, inside a current internship or a first job. The most powerful for someone already in it is verification: be the person who catches the generated model or research summary that's confidently wrong. That requires understanding the business well enough to smell an implausible number — exactly what the old modeling years used to build, and exactly what major firms are now testing for in final rounds. You can start building it this term, not after some future qualification.

The career-hunting checklist

The analysis tells you where the exposure is. This is what to do about it — the part that's actually in your hands. Most of the protection in finance is built here, in these habits and choices, rather than handed to you. The first list is for anyone still in the degree; the second is for the job hunt itself.

During the degree — build toward the accountable seat

- **Treat the destination as the product, not the degree.** The protection in finance lives at the tiers where a named human is answerable — wealth advisory (4.6), risk and compliance (5.3) — not in the entry-analyst rung that scores 8.0. Aim every choice at being answerable to a client or a regulator.
- **Understand the recruiting timeline before it runs out.** Investment banking summer analyst applications open up to eighteen months in advance; if banking is of any interest, the process starts in first year, not third. Missing it is missing it.
- **Treat the internship as non-negotiable.** It is now the primary filter for full-time offers, not one input among several, and the single strongest signal you can carry.
- **Take the quantitative modules seriously.** Statistics, econometrics and modeling as reasoning — that's the judgment layer verification depends on, not software training you can pick up later.
- **Point at the under-applied lanes on purpose.** Wealth advisory, risk and compliance score better and hire more readily, and almost nobody your age is applying to them. Everyone chases banking; that's the crowded, exposed door.
- **Get fluent with AI as a worker, not a shortcut.** Learn to direct a model build and catch it when it's confidently wrong — firms now test for exactly this, including in final rounds.

- **Feed curiosity and adaptability on purpose.** The modeling suite and the research platform will turn over repeatedly; the person who stays commercially curious and re-tools fastest compounds.
- **Keep the frame wide.** Properly vet the alternatives — advisory versus banking, risk, and accounting, where licensed CPA advisory scores 5.2 — before committing to the oversubscribed end.

During the job hunt — aim for the room, don't just apply

- **Target the protected lanes on purpose.** Wealth advisory (4.6), risk and compliance (5.3), a path toward the accountable seat — not "analyst, open to anything," which points straight at the 8.0.
- **Read the title, not just the offer.** Entry analyst and research roles are the automating layer (8.0), and corporate finance / FP&A (6.8) sits close behind. If you take one, take it as a deliberate stepping-stone toward a client-facing or accountable seat, not as the plan.
- **Don't grab a role just because it's on offer in an exposed lane.** A role being available doesn't make it safe. A firm still running a large analyst intake may simply be behind the curve — and that's exactly the rung whose training has changed even where the seats remain. Availability can be a lagging indicator, not a green light.
- **Prefer the seat closest to a client or a regulator.** Advisory over analysis, a role where someone is answerable over one that produces materials for someone else to sign — proximity to accountability is proximity to the protection.
- **Ask the employer where AI is heading in the role.** Whether they're building the job around directing and verifying these tools, or waiting to be forced to, tells you if the seat grows or is quietly being hollowed out.
- **Weigh trajectory over starting salary.** The banking end pays \$85,000–\$100,000 at entry and is the most exposed tier at once — a lower-paid seat that puts you closer to a client and builds AI fluency can age far better.

Go deeper — further reading

- **Financial Analysts — Occupational Outlook Handbook** — US Bureau of Labor Statistics. The primary source for growth projections and wage distributions, free and updated regularly. Read this before any recruiting-firm forecast.

- **Investment Banking USA Hiring Outlook 2026** — Selby Jennings. Useful for where demand is actually concentrated — restructuring, private capital, secondaries, technology and infrastructure — and for the observation that hiring is strongest at associate and VP level. Note this is a recruiting firm; read it for the directional picture rather than as neutral analysis.
- **Are too many students choosing finance?** — on the split between oversubscribed glamorous roles and under-filled ones. The most useful corrective to how students actually apply.

The counterargument — read this one:

The strongest case against our 8.0 is that we are scoring a **cycle** and calling it a **structure**.

Deal activity collapsed in 2023–24 and analyst hiring collapsed with it. Both have since recovered, and industry commentary now describes banks as understaffed against rebounding transaction volume. On this reading, the entry-level compression we're measuring is the ordinary bottom of a cycle that has already turned, and attributing it to AI mistakes timing for causation.

Where we land: we take this seriously enough to have written it into the honest caveat about the trend rather than leaving it here, and it is the single largest source of uncertainty in this guide. What holds our score is that the content of the first-year role has changed even where the headcount recovers — when firms interview for the ability to direct AI through modeling rather than to build models, the apprenticeship has been redesigned regardless of how many seats exist.

But if analyst classes return to pre-2023 size and the work returns with them, we are wrong and we will lower the score. That is a specific, falsifiable claim and we'll report it either way.

Bottom line

Finance's protected end is genuinely protected, and it is not where students are looking — which is exactly why being already in it is not a problem. The decisive moves were always going to happen from here.

Wealth advisory at 4.6 and risk at 5.3 are shielded by the two things that hold up across this whole index: a named human answerable to a client, and regulatory obligation attached to a person. Neither is going anywhere.

The entry tier is the problem, and it is severe — 8.0, with a job description that reads like a list of automated tasks. Hiring has shifted toward experience, and the training the analyst years used to provide has changed even where the seats remain. Standing still on that rung is the one thing not to do.

And the practical advice is unusually concrete for this guide. Understand the recruiting timeline, because it starts eighteen months ahead of the job and the internship is now the filter rather than one input among several. If you're early in the degree and banking is of any interest, that clock is the first thing to check.

So the useful advice isn't a verdict on the degree — it's a direction. Aim at advisory, risk or compliance rather than assuming banking. Take the quantitative modules seriously, because verification depends on them. Get the internship. Move toward being answerable to someone as early as you can. And build real AI fluency now — verification above all — inside whatever role you're in, because that's the differentiator this field rewards fastest.

And one honest thing worth saying. The advisory end of finance — sitting with someone making the most consequential financial decision of their life and being the person they trust — is work people describe in terms very close to vocation. It scores 4.6, it hires readily, and almost nobody applies to it. That combination is rare, and it's still available to you from where you stand.

Questions worth sitting with

Whether you're the one in it or a parent thinking it through, these are the conversations that move the needle now. Read "you" as whoever the decision is about.

Where you actually stand

1. Which tier are you on — or aiming at — and does it point at someone answerable to a client (wealth advisory, risk) or at producing materials someone else signs (entry analyst, research)? 2. Looking at the score table, which destination are you currently pointed at, and is it the one you'd choose on purpose? 3. If banking is of any interest, where are you against the eighteen-month recruiting clock — on time, or has it already run?

The move from here

4. What's the single most protected role you could realistically aim for from where you are now, and what would make you a credible candidate for it? 5. If you're still studying: are the under-applied lanes — wealth advisory, risk, compliance — on your list, or are you defaulting to the oversubscribed banking end? 6. If you're job-hunting: are you aiming at a protected lane on purpose, or applying to whatever's open? Name the three roles you're actually chasing, and whether any puts you near a client.

The AI question, practically

7. Of the five capabilities — verify, direct, judge what matters, build trust early, understand where models fail — which one could you visibly demonstrate within the next few months? 8. Can you point to a moment where you caught a generated model or research summary that was confidently wrong? If not, where's the easiest place to start building that skill?

Testing it against reality

9. **The most valuable single action:** find someone two to three years into finance and ask what they actually did in year one, and whether that work still exists. 10. If the first offer that comes is an entry-analyst or research role, what's your plan — take it as a deliberate stepping-stone toward an accountable seat, or hold out for something closer to a client? Decide before the offer, not after.

This is analysis and informed judgment about a fast-moving situation. For finance specifically, we've flagged that this is the most cyclical profession we score, that some of the measured movement is likely the deal cycle rather than automation, and that we cannot cleanly separate the two.

Scores for 2023 and 2025 are retrospectively calculated using the current methodology. Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed.

Technical scoring appendix — Finance

Pivotum Degree Risk Index — Fall 2026 Edition

This appendix is the audit trail. It sets out the formula, the rating anchors, every factor rating behind every track score in this profile, the backcast arithmetic, a sensitivity analysis, and the specific things that would change our mind.

We publish it because a score nobody can check is an opinion with a decimal point.

1. The formula

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Risk} = & 0.35 \times \text{Automatability} \\ & + 0.15 \times \text{EntryErosion} \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Physical}) \\ & + 0.15 \times (10 - \text{Trust}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Regulatory}) \\ & + 0.10 \times (10 - \text{Judgment}) \end{aligned}$$

Two exposure factors carry 50% of the weight; three protection factors carry 40%; judgment under novelty carries the remaining 10% and sits on the protection side. The deliberate consequence is that protection can outweigh exposure — which is why a highly automatable job like teaching still scores low.

Bands. Very low below 3.0 · Low 3.0–4.4 · Moderate 4.5–5.4 · Moderate–High 5.5–6.9 · High 7.0 and above.

2. Rating anchors

HOW THE 0–10 RAW RATINGS ARE ANCHORED

Every factor is rated on its own 0–10 scale before weighting. The anchors are identical across all twenty-eight careers, which is what makes the scores comparable.

Task automatability (A) — *what share of the working week could a capable current system already do to an acceptable standard?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Almost nothing. The work is physical, relational or wholly novel.
3–4	Administrative surround only — notes, scheduling, correspondence.
5–6	A meaningful minority of the week, mostly documentation and lookup.
7–8	A large share, including tasks central to the junior version of the role.
9–10	Most of the described duties, at or near professional standard.

Entry-path erosion (E) — *how much has the traditional route into this work narrowed?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Protected by statute or physical necessity. Training hours cannot be automated.
3–4	Stable. Some junior tasks absorbed; the apprenticeship survives.
5–6	Visible narrowing. Employers prefer experience; junior intake reduced.
7–8	Substantial. The work juniors learned on has largely gone.
9–10	The training layer and the automatable layer were the same layer.

Physical / embodied (P) — *must this be done in person, with a body, in an unpredictable setting?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Fully screen-based. Location-independent.
3–4	Occasional presence; the core work is not physical.
5–6	Regular physical presence, in largely controlled conditions.
7–8	Substantially physical, with some variability of setting.
9–10	Irreducibly physical, in conditions that differ every time.

Human trust / accountability (T) — *does someone need a specific human they can rely on, and must a human answer when it goes wrong?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Output is anonymous and reviewed by others.
3–4	Work is signed off by someone else. No personal reliance.
5–6	Some client relationship; accountability is institutional.
7–8	Named responsibility, with commercial or professional consequence.
9–10	The relationship is the service, and liability attaches personally.

Regulatory / licensing (R) — *does the law reserve this act to a qualified human?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	No license exists and none is proposed.
3–4	Certification is customary but not reserved.
5–6	Partial reservation, varying by jurisdiction or task.
7–8	Licensed practice, with some unreserved adjacent work.
9–10	Comprehensive statutory reservation, including of the training route.

Judgment under novelty (J) — *how often does the work present something with no matching precedent, where being wrong is costly?*

RATING	ANCHOR
0–2	Routine by design. Deviation is an error, not a case.
3–4	Occasional exceptions, handled by escalation.
5–6	Regular non-standard cases within a known range.
7–8	Frequent genuine novelty with material consequences.
9–10	Novelty is constant, and in some fields adversarially generated.

3. Factor ratings by track

Ratings are the Fall 2026 edition unless a range is shown. **P, T, R and J are held constant across editions** — those protections are structural and do not move on a three-year horizon. All measured movement is in A and E.

WEALTH / FINANCIAL ADVISORY — 4.6 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.4	5.0	6.0	2.1
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.0	3.4	3.8	0.57
Physical / embodied	15%	1.5	1.5	1.5	1.27
Human trust / accountability	15%	9.0	9.0	9.0	0.15
Regulatory / licensing	10%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.25
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.25
				Total	4.59 → 4.6

RISK & COMPLIANCE — 5.3 (MODERATE)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	4.7	5.4	6.6	2.31
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.5	3.9	4.4	0.66
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.38
Regulatory / licensing	10%	6.5	6.5	6.5	0.35
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.25
				Total	5.29 → 5.3

INVESTMENT BANKING (SENIOR) — 5.7 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.0	6.0	7.0	2.45
Entry-path erosion	15%	3.8	4.2	4.6	0.69
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.38
Regulatory / licensing	10%	4.0	4.0	4.0	0.6
Judgment under novelty	10%	7.5	7.5	7.5	0.25
				Total	5.71 → 5.7

CORPORATE FINANCE / FP&A — 6.8 (MODERATE-HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	6.4	7.3	8.2	2.87
Entry-path erosion	15%	4.8	5.3	5.8	0.87
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.6
Regulatory / licensing	10%	3.0	3.0	3.0	0.7
Judgment under novelty	10%	6.0	6.0	6.0	0.4
				Total	6.79 → 6.8

ENTRY ANALYST / RESEARCH — 8.0 (HIGH)

FACTOR	WEIGHT	2023	2025	2026	CONTRIBUTION TO 2026 SCORE
Task automatability	35%	5.7	7.8	9.4	3.29
Entry-path erosion	15%	6.0	7.2	8.0	1.2
Physical / embodied	15%	1.0	1.0	1.0	1.35
Human trust / accountability	15%	4.0	4.0	4.0	0.9
Regulatory / licensing	10%	3.0	3.0	3.0	0.7
Judgment under novelty	10%	4.5	4.5	4.5	0.55
				Total	7.99 → 8.0

4. Backcast arithmetic

Worked example for the headline track, showing exactly how the three-year movement is composed.

Wealth / financial advisory

EDITION	A	E	PROTECTION DEFICIT (FIXED)	SCORE
2023	4.4	3.0	1.92	3.9
2025	5.0	3.4	1.92	4.2
Fall 2026	6.0	3.8	1.92	4.6

Movement decomposition: automatability contributed **+0.56** and entry-path erosion **+0.12**, for a total of **+0.7** points over three years.

The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology, not archived scores from published editions. They are our best assessment of what each factor would have rated at the time, given what was then demonstrable. They are not measurements.

5. Sensitivity

How far the score moves if a single factor is rated one point differently:

FACTOR	±1 POINT MOVES THE SCORE BY
Task automatability	±0.35
Entry-path erosion	±0.15
Physical / embodied	±0.15
Human trust / accountability	±0.15
Regulatory / licensing	±0.10
Judgment under novelty	±0.10

What this means in practice. A one-point disagreement about automatability moves a score by 0.35 — enough to shift a track between bands at the margins. A one-point disagreement about licensing moves it by 0.10, which almost never changes a band.

So if you disagree with one of our numbers, the automatability rating is where the disagreement matters most, and it is the rating we would most want challenged.

6. Stated limitations

We measure capability, not deployment. Scores reflect exposure to what AI can already do at the leading edge — not how much any particular employer has adopted. Adoption lags capability by years and lags unevenly: large, well-funded organisations first; small, rural, public-sector and thin-margin employers much later. The lag is a buffer, not a shelter. It buys time without changing direction.

We do not measure demand. A task can be highly automatable and highly in demand simultaneously. Where the labor market and our framework disagree, we say so in the profile rather than adjusting the score to fit.

We do not measure oversupply. The number of people entering a field is outside our six factors, and for some careers it matters more than automation.

We do not measure industry economics. A profession can contract for reasons entirely unrelated to technology.

We do not measure whether the work is worth doing. Pay, satisfaction, debt, hours and meaning sit outside the score and are covered separately in each profile — often at greater length, because for several careers they matter more.

Sub-track definitions are ours. Job titles vary between employers and countries. We have chosen tracks that reflect genuinely different work, not official classifications.

7. What would change our mind

Each edition names specific, checkable indicators. If these move, the scores move — including downward.

Across the index:

- **Graduate hiring share.** If employers in the professions where we rate entry-path erosion highly return to hiring juniors at pre-2023 rates, those ratings fall.
- **Content of mandated training hours.** Several professions protect their on-ramp through required supervised experience. If the content of those hours shifts from producing work to supervising it, the protection weakens without any rule changing.
- **Offsite and prefabricated construction share.** The clearest test of our physical-protection ratings: automation performs well in controlled settings, so moving work indoors raises exposure without any robotics breakthrough.
- **Verified deployment rather than capability.** If adoption stalls materially below capability for several editions, our leading-indicator approach is overstating near-term risk and we will say so.

We will report movement in either direction. A framework that only ever revises upward is not measuring anything.

Scores measure exposure to what AI can already do — not how much any particular employer has deployed. The 2023 and 2025 figures are retrospective reconstructions using the current methodology.